

mpions

m turned them into world-beaters.

cluttering tactics with theory. The captain turned out to be quite a leader and the support staff on call made many. Viv Richards included, question whether the team needed a head coach at all.

In five years' time, India's victory at the World T20 could be marked down as the moment that India's next generation of players broke through and accepted that they had to be the doers and decision-makers or history would mock them. After years of flickering promise, a clutch of players charted their own course with bat and ball. On



HEROES: The reception in Mumbai, and (right) exuberance on the field

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the field younger legs produced a run out per game and the team called "The Unstoppables" during the England one-day series, could not be stopped.

The format of the T20 may have suited every Indian player's own game. The lack of any expectations may have given them what Steve Waugh called "a sense of freedom". It is a matter of debate as to how free and easy R.P. Singh felt when up against the rampaging Misbah-ul-Haq. Whatever else it was for India, the World T20 was not an easy ride.

Captain Dhoni, who mixes breeziness with common sense, believes the victory is the result of his team's "will to win". Bowling coach Venkatesh Prasad says it was "confidence" while his colleague Robin Singh calls it a positive mindset. This unquantifiable, indefinable quality grew through the tournament and in 15 days, the Indians made the transition from mere teammates to a brotherhood of the determined. When they started out, the entire crew had something to prove. Gautam Gambhir and Robin Uthappa had to push their claims for permanent slots in the one-day team. Yuvraj Singh was riled by a question whether he was in the team for his bowling only. Harbhajan Singh and Virender Sehwag needed to get back into the Indian team. Every man's disparate reason turned into a common goal.

One of those was R.P. Singh, who defied predictions that like all medium pacers he too would be unable to dic-